

Synonym

文 95 languages

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For other uses, see [Synonym \(disambiguation\)](#).

A **synonym** is a **word**, **morpheme**, or **phrase** that means precisely or nearly the same as another word, morpheme, or phrase in a given language.^[2] For example, in the **English language**, the words *begin*, *start*, *commence*, and *initiate* are all synonyms of one another: they are *synonymous*. The standard test for synonymy is substitution: one form can be replaced by another in a sentence without changing its meaning.

Words may often be synonymous in only one particular [sense](#): for example, *long* and *extended* in the [context](#) *long time* or *extended time* are synonymous, but *long* cannot be used in the phrase *extended family*.

Synonyms with exactly the same meaning share a **seme** or denotational **sememe**, whereas those with inexactly similar meanings share a broader denotational or **connotational** sememe and thus overlap within a **semantic field**. The former are sometimes called **cognitive synonyms** and the latter, near-synonyms,^[3] plesionyms^[4] or poecilonyms.^[5]



Synonym list in [cuneiform](#) on a clay tablet. [Neo-Assyrian](#) period^[1]

Lexicography

Some **lexicographers** claim that no synonyms have exactly the same meaning (in all contexts or social levels of language) because **etymology**, **orthography**, phonic qualities, **connotations**, ambiguous meanings, **usage**, and so on make them unique.^[6] Different words that are similar in meaning usually differ for a reason: *feline* is more formal than *cat*; *long* and *extended* are only synonyms in one usage and not in others (for example, a *long arm* is not the same as an *extended arm*). Synonyms are also a source of **euphemisms**.

Metonymy can sometimes be a form of synonymy: the *White House* is used as a synonym of the *administration* in referring to the **U.S. executive branch** under a specific president.^[7] Thus, a metonym is a type of synonym, and the word *metonym* is a **hyponym** of the word *synonym*.^[citation needed]

The analysis of synonymy, [polysemy](#), hyponymy, and hypernymy is inherent to [taxonomy](#) and [ontology](#) in the [information science](#) senses of those terms.^[8] It has applications in [pedagogy](#) and [machine learning](#), because they rely on [word-sense disambiguation](#).^[9]

Etymology

The word is borrowed from [Latin](#) *synonymum*, in turn borrowed from [Ancient Greek](#) *synōnymon* (συνώνυμον), composed of *sýn* (σύν 'together, similar, alike') and *-ōnym-* (-ωνυμ-), a form of *ónoma* (ὄνομα 'name').^[10]

Sources

Synonyms are often from the different [strata](#) making up a language. For example, in English, [Norman French superstratum](#) words and [Old English substratum](#) words continue to coexist.^[11] Thus, today there exist synonyms like the Norman-derived *people*, *liberty* and *archer*, and the Saxon-derived *folk*, *freedom* and *bowman*. For more examples, see the [list of Germanic and Latinate equivalents in English](#).

Loanwords are another rich source of synonyms, often from the language of the dominant culture of a region. Thus, most European languages have borrowed from Latin and ancient Greek, especially for technical terms, but the native terms continue to be used in non-technical contexts. In **East Asia**, borrowings from **Chinese** in **Japanese**, **Korean**, and **Vietnamese** often exist alongside native words. In Islamic cultures, **Arabic** and **Persian** are large sources of synonymous borrowings.

For example, in **Turkish**, *kara* and *siyah* both mean 'black', the former being a native Turkish word, and the latter being a borrowing from Persian. In **Ottoman Turkish**, there were often three synonyms: water can be *su* (Turkish), *âb* (Persian), or *mâ* (Arabic): "such a triad of synonyms exists in Ottoman for every meaning, without exception". As always with synonyms, there are nuances and shades of meaning or usage.^[12]

In English, similarly, there often exist Latin (L) and Greek (Gk) terms synonymous with Germanic ones: *thought*, *notion* (L), *idea* (Gk); *ring*, *circle* (L), *cycle* (Gk). English often uses the Germanic term only as a noun, but has Latin and Greek adjectives: *hand*, *manual* (L), *chiral* (Gk); *heat*, *thermal* (L), *caloric* (Gk). Sometimes the Germanic term has become rare, or restricted to special meanings: *tide*, *time/temporal*, *chronic*.^[13]

Many **bound morphemes** in English are borrowed from Latin and Greek and are synonyms for native words or morphemes: *fish*, *pisci-* (L), *ichthy-* (Gk).

Another source of synonyms is [coinages](#), which may be motivated by [linguistic purism](#). Thus, the English word *foreword* was coined to replace the Romance *preface*. In Turkish, *ökl* was coined to replace the Arabic-derived *mektep* and *mederese*, but those words continue to be used in some contexts.^[14]

Uses

Synonyms often express a nuance of meaning or are used in different **registers** of speech or writing.

Various technical domains may employ synonyms to convey precise technical nuances.

Some writers avoid repeating the same word in close proximity, and prefer to use synonyms: this is called **elegant variation**. Many modern style guides criticize this.

Examples

Synonyms can be any **part of speech**, as long as both words belong to the same part of speech. Examples:

- noun: *drink* and *beverage*
- verb: *buy* and *purchase*
- adjective: *big* and *large*
- adverb: *quickly* and *speedily*
- preposition: *on* and *upon*

Synonyms are defined with respect to certain senses of words: *pupil* as the *aperture in the iris of the eye* is not synonymous with *student*. Similarly, *he expired* means the same as *he died*, yet *my passport has expired* cannot be replaced by *my passport has died*.

A **thesaurus or synonym dictionary** lists similar or related words; these are often, but not always, synonyms.^[15]

- The word **poecilonym** is a rare synonym of the word *synonym*. It is not entered in most major dictionaries and is a curiosity or piece of trivia for being an **autological word** because of its **meta** quality as a synonym of *synonym*.
- **Antonyms** are words with opposite or nearly opposite meanings. For example: *hot* ↔ *cold*, *large* ↔ *small*, *thick* ↔ *thin*, *synonym* ↔ *antonym*
- **Hypernyms and hyponyms** are words that refer to, respectively, a general category and a specific instance of that category. For example, *vehicle* is a hypernym of *car*, and *car* is a hyponym of *vehicle*.
- **Homophones** are words that have the same pronunciation but different meanings. For example, *witch* and *which* are homophones in most accents (because they are pronounced the same).
- **Homographs** are words that have the same spelling but different meanings. For example, one can *record* a song or keep a *record* of documents.
- **Homonyms** are words that have the same pronunciation and spelling but different meanings. For example, *rose* (a type of flower) and *rose* (past tense of *rise*) are homonyms.

See also

- -onym
- Cognitive synonymy
- **Elegant variation**, the gratuitous use of a synonym in prose
- Semantic equivalence (linguistics)
- Synonym (taxonomy)
- Synonymy in Japanese
- Synonym ring
- Thesauri and synonym dictionaries – Reference work for synonyms

References

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